Swadeshi movement; the government's decision to slap sedition cases on VOC and his comrades were made after consulting him.)

With Captain E.J. Headlam, director of the Royal Indian Marine as the president, the committee consisted of the following members: Sir Arthur H. Froom,[18] partner of Mackinnon, Mackenzie and Company (the Managing Agents of BI), representing British shipping interests; Lalubhai Samaldas of the Scindia Steam Navigation Company and Jadunath Roy, of the Bengal National Chamber of Commerce, both representing Indian interests; John Biles, a consulting navy architect to the India Office and Tiruvenkata Rangachariar, a legislator.[19]

The terms of reference included recommending measures for 'the liberal recruitment of Indians as deck and executive officers and engineers in the Royal Indian Marine'; 'the establishment of a Nautical College in Indian waters' for training Indian apprentices and encouraging shipbuilding and fostering an Indian mercantile marine by 'a system of bounties, subsidies and such other measures' similar to those adopted by Japan. Evidently, the strain on the shipping industry during World War I weighed heavily on the minds of India's imperial masters.

The report recommended the Indianizing of coastal marine trade over a period of twenty years and recommended the revival of Indian shipbuilding with the help of government bounties. A strong case was made for providing nautical training to Indian youths. However, BI's Arthur Froom wrote a strong dissent note claiming that the report smacked of 'expropriation and flag discrimination'. This was a virtual veto, and it should come as no surprise that nothing came of the report. The government took two years to even study the report. The socialist Asoka Mehta, writing a few years before Independence, called the report nothing less than a 'Homeric battle waged between Government and British interests on the one side and Indian nationalist opinion on the other'.[20] Needless to say, the Indian shipping industry was deeply disappointed.[21]

Despite being foredoomed to failure, the report itself is revealing. The written statements, in response to a detailed questionnaire, by 128 witnesses